

Windows XP was also capable of offering a lower level of account, but this removed from the users hands the capability to make everyday changes to the system such as changing the time zone, or install a new device (a camera, for example). The inability to make such changes was one of the major reason that both home users and office computers were often configured with full-access under Windows XP.

Vista offers a middle road which, while allowing a level of flexibility to what a user can or cannot do inside an OS, also keeps security primarily in mind. Under Vista, there are two types of user accounts: the Administrator account and the standard user account. “Standard user accounts” are equivalent to the similar standard user account in previous versions of Windows. They have limited administrative privileges and user rights—they cannot install or uninstall applications that install into system’s root directory, change system settings, or perform other administrative tasks. However, standard users can perform these tasks if they are able to provide valid administrative credentials when prompted. This is to be expected; what Vista does differently is how it treats the Administrator accounts. While in the previous versions of Windows, an administrator account was granted the right to do any change needed, Vista limits the account privileges at the onset. With UAC enabled, members of the local Administrators group run with the same access token as standard users. The system grants the Administrator full rights only when the user grants the approval. This fundamental change is the cornerstone of User Account Control under Vista. There are thus three possible scenarios:

1. You are logged in as administrator: by default you are actually running as a standard user and all applications running in the session are also running with low-privilege settings. Thus when an application needs to make system-level changes you will be prompted by the operating system to verify, confirm, and allow that program or task to make the changes. This verification takes the form of a prompt, generally referred to as the eleva-